

Playing Catch up

From time to time, Microsoft releases Service Packs for Windows, Office and Internet Explorer. Each Service Pack is a bundle of all updates and patches for the software. If you haven't updated yet, just look up the latest Service Pack and install it instead of hunting for individual updates. Service Packs are also safer since they contain deployed, tested and extensively used patches. The original patch may have had another bug that would be fixed before including it in a Service Pack.

patches are applied and also results in smaller file downloads.

For Internet Explorer updates, visit <http://www.microsoft.com/windows/ie/default.asp> and look up 'Critical Updates' under 'Downloads'. A list of updates for your browser and related software with descriptions of each patch is provided. As with Windows and Office, you will find Service Packs that contain all patches before its release date. Be sure to check for patches regularly, since security holes can leave your PC open to hackers and worms as you use your browser online.

Tools of the trade

There are several other tools, some free, others at a price, that let you manage bugs, fixes, updates and patches for Windows. They scan and monitor your system and inform you of possibly outdated files. Here are some of them:

CNET CatchUp

<http://catchup.cnet.com/>

CNET CatchUp makes it very easy to download software updates and security fixes. Once installed, it will automatically take you to the service page where you can scan your PC for software, security vulnerabilities or even hardware and third-party components that require updating.

PatchWork

<http://www.cisecurity.org/patchwork.html>

PatchWork is a free utility that checks



CNET CatchUp scans your PC for out-of-date software

Windows NT and 2000 systems for documented vulnerabilities. As you launch the program, it tells you if your system is secure, the vulnerabilities found and even leads you to the sites where you can read more about the security threat. It also takes you to the Microsoft Windows Update site for getting the relevant updates. You can even set it to 'Quick Check' from 'Options' so that it runs automatically at startup.



PatchWork is a tiny tool that scans your servers for security holes

UpdateEXPERT

http://www.stbernard.com/products/updateexpert/products_updateexpert.asp

UpdateEXPERT is a patch assessment tool for enterprises. It can scan networked systems for missing patches and fix the weaknesses it finds. It works with almost all versions of Windows, but comes at a price. The first time you run UpdateEXPERT, a wizard helps you set up the software for all the machines you want to manage. The software analyses and reports the status of every machine and advises on missing updates. Click on the bug to read its documentation, then right-click and select 'Install' to download and install the patch.

Links Bank

Active Network is a complete resource guide for Windows and other Microsoft products. This site provides lists of bugs under various sections.

www.activewin.com

Beyond-Security's SecuriTeam.com is where you get your daily updates of security flaws and security-related tools. You can even get security alerts on your mobile phone or other handheld devices.

www.securiteam.com

BigFix monitors your PC for bugs, security holes and viruses, and fixes them before they cause damage.

www.bigfix.com

BugNet provides regular bug alerts for all kinds of software. You can even report any bugs you find, browse through the analysis of bugs and sign up for the free newsletter.

www.bugnet.com

Patchlink boasts of being the world's largest repository of patches. They also have an enterprise-wide patch management software, but you have to pay for it.

www.patchlink.com

PCWorld Bugs and Fixes has a comprehensive archive of bugs and patches for several software, which is regularly updated with new reports.

<http://www.pcworld.com/howto/locations/0,loc,12,00.asp>

WinPlanet gives regular news on all the flavours of Windows. It also links you to **WinDrivers.com**, where you can find the latest Windows drivers for all your hardware.

www.winplanet.com

WinPortal.com is dedicated to Windows 2000. Apart from news and security threats, the software sections are very useful, with downloads to manage your applications, drivers, patches, etc.

www.winportal.com

Woody's Office Portal hosts e-zines on Office and Windows which can be subscribed to or read online.

www.wopr.com

ZDNetIndia.com not only has the regular news updates, but also two very good services: Virus Workshop and Security Central. This is where you can keep yourself updated on virus and security threats.

www.zdnetindia.com